

Today, many of the club's players represent the Kancheepuram District Football Association, with many of them coming from the Sirukalathur Government School, a team that regularly advances from local tournaments to district-level competitions.

The impact extends beyond football. Players have secured college admissions, with some now representing institutions such as Hindustan Institute of Technology & Science and Loyola College.

From a single ground, the numbers tell their own story: one Santosh Trophy player, three junior nationals, over 20 university-level players, and a growing presence in club football.

Making waves: Sirukalathur Galatipet Football Club U-17 team at the Reliance Foundation Youth Sports league. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

A small and trusted circle

What allows one man to influence an entire village, and parents to trust him with their children, becomes clearer upon visiting Sirukalathur.

Colourful flags outline the pitch. Narrow streets connect tightly packed houses, many with cows and goats. Dairy farming sustains a large section of the population, while others work as daily-wage labourers. Around 90 to 100 people hold government jobs.

At the centre of it all is Harikrishnan's office, its walls lined with trophies and photographs, markers of a steady rise. Since 2019, Sirukalathur has been a consistent presence in the Kancheepuram District Championships, lifting titles in the Third Division in 2019 and the First Division in 2024. They were runners-up in the Second Division in 2023 and the First Division in 2025.

His journey, however, has been far from straightforward.

"My father used to drink a lot, and

my mother endured a lot while raising me. I failed Class 10. Though I wanted to study, I loved playing sport," Harikrishnan said.

"I tried again and passed. In Class 12, I failed English, wrote it again, and cleared it. I was a volleyball player in college, but I only picked up the sport in Class 11. I did not even have money to buy proper shoes," he added.

Born and raised in the same village, Harikrishnan was among the first to clear and prepare the ground, once filled with garbage, that now serves as the club's base. Plans are in place to add a seating pavilion, install floodlights, and build a swimming pool. But the ideas hit a standstill as the pandemic wreaked havoc.

As substance abuse rose during the 2020 lockdown, the club decided to go beyond coaching in difficult times.

It began providing breakfast and dinner to regular trainees.

"Most of the boys and girls are not

